

France



Europe's first modern republic, and a prime mover for European integration.

600 BCE Greeks found colony of Massalia on the Mediterranean coast and other trading colonies. They trade tin and other commodities up the Rhône and into northern and western France with the Celts and other peoples.

121 BCE Southern France is occupied by the Romans and becomes the province of Gallia Narbonensis.

105 BCE Two Roman armies are destroyed by the Cimbri and Teutones—Germanic tribes—at Arausio in the Rhône valley in 105 BCE. The Cimbri move on to invade Spain, but the Roman dictator Marius rallies his troops and defeats the Cimbri at Aquae Sextiae in 102 BCE.

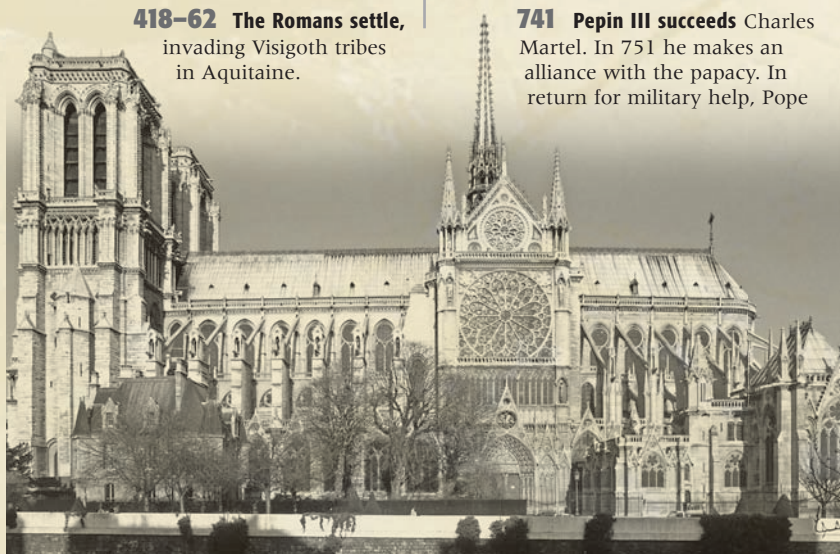
58–51 BCE The Romans, under Julius Caesar, conquer Gaul, an area roughly equivalent to modern France, defeating Vercingetorix at Alesia in 52 BCE. The new territory is divided into Gallia Lugdunensis in the north, Gallia Belgica in the northeast, and Aquitania in the west. A rebellion against Roman rule in 26 CE is crushed.

253 CE Frankish tribes from Germany first cross the Rhine into Gaul.

260 Postumus usurps power in Gaul and creates an independent Roman empire including Britannia and Hispaniae (Spain), which lasts until 274. He secures power by defending his Gallic Empire's frontiers against barbarian attack.

406 A coalition of Vandals, Suevi, and Alans invades Gaul before crossing into Spain. They are followed into Gaul by Franks, Burgundians, and Alemanni.

418–62 The Romans settle, invading Visigoth tribes in Aquitaine.



Church to the kings of France

Built on the eastern half of the Île de la Cité in Paris between 1163 and 1257, Notre Dame is one of Europe's finest examples of early Gothic architecture. As the "parish church of the kings of France," it also saw the coronation of Henry VI of England, crowned king of France in 1431.

451 Attila the Hun invades Gaul but is defeated by a coalition of Romans, Franks, and Visigoths.

486 Roman power in Gaul ("Francia") finally collapses when Syagrius, the last Roman commander, is defeated by Clovis I, the first of the Merovingian kings, at Soissons. Clovis's reign marks the foundation of the Frankish empire that soon covers western and northern France, except Brittany, and extends east into the Low Countries and Germany. The Burgundians control the south and east, and the Visigoths the far southwest.

496 Clovis and the Franks convert to Christianity. This wins them the support of their Gallo-Roman subjects and of eastern Roman emperors. Gradually eliminating rivals, the Frankish kingdom becomes the strongest power in Europe by 600.

507 Clovis defeats the Visigoths at Vouillé, driving them into Spain.

511 Clovis dies and his kingdom is divided among his four sons, as is the Germanic custom. This has the effect of weakening the kingdom, resulting in instability, civil war, and assassinations.

561 The kingdom is divided again, between the sons of Clothar I.

639 With the death of King Dagobert, a succession of weak Merovingian kings sees power pass to the mayor of the palace, a high-ranking court official.

670 As Frankish power declines, Aquitaine breaks away and is not taken back into the kingdom until 768.

679–714 Pepin II of Herstal is the most successful mayor of the palace. He is effective ruler of the entire kingdom.

732 Mayor Charles Martel defeats an invading Muslim army at Poitiers, ending Muslim expansion in western Europe.

741 Pepin III succeeds Charles Martel. In 751 he makes an alliance with the papacy. In return for military help, Pope

RENAISSANCE KING (1494–1547)

FRANCIS I

Francis I succeeded to the French crown in 1515 upon the death of his wife's father, Louis XII, since women were prohibited from inheriting the throne. Francis was France's first Renaissance king, surrounding himself with musicians and poets at his court, where visitors included Leonardo da Vinci.

While his reign proved the catalyst for a flowering of the arts, Francis's political record was more mixed. He was defeated by Habsburg emperor Charles V at the Battle of Pavia in 1525 and forced to surrender any claims in Italy after a period of imprisonment. However, one of Francis's lasting legacies was the historic accommodation he reached with the Ottoman Turks, who became allies of France during the Italian War (1542–46).



Zacharias authorizes him to depose the Merovingian king and assume the kingship of the Franks himself as the first Carolingian king.

768 On the death of Pepin III, the kingdom is divided between his two sons, Charlemagne and Carloman. When Carloman dies in 771, Charlemagne is sole ruler. He conquers the Lombard kingdom of Italy in 774 and doubles the size of his kingdom by 800, extending its borders from northern Spain to the Elbe in Germany. His capital at Aachen is the intellectual center of Europe.

799 Fiercely independent Brittany is conquered by Charlemagne, although it rebels in 812.

800 King Charlemagne is crowned Emperor of the West by Pope Leo III and effectively establishes the Carolingian empire.

806 Charlemagne sets up a chain of customs posts in eastern Germany to control trade with the Slavs.

814 Charlemagne dies and is succeeded by Louis the Pious, who dies in 840. Civil war breaks out between his younger sons for the succession.

843 Treaty of Verdun divides Charlemagne's empire into three: West Francia (France), East Francia (Germany), and Italy. The empire is briefly reunited under Charles the Fat (884–87) but it finally breaks up into five kingdoms as Burgundy and Provence break away.

911 Charles the Simple allows Norse raiders to settle in Normandy.

987 The Capetian dynasty, which lasts until 1328 and succeeds that of the Carolingians, is founded by Hugh Capet (987–996), although it is not until the late 12th century that the Capetian realm attains its greatest territorial extent.

1066 Duke William of Normandy invades England and seizes the throne, starting 400 years of conflict over lands owned by the English kings in France.

1154 Henry II of England rules the vast Angevin empire in France, a territory far bigger than that of the French king.

1180–1223 Philip Augustus is king and revives the monarchy. He defeats an Anglo-German invasion at Bouvines in 1214, recovering all English lands in France except Gascony, and makes France the strongest nation in Europe.

1309 The papacy is moved from Rome to Avignon in France by Pope Clement V. From 1378, during the period of the Great Schism, there are two rival popes, until the Roman party achieves sole recognition in 1417 and returns the papacy to Rome.

1328 Philip VI is first Valois king.

1337 The Hundred Years War, between France and England, begins when Edward III of England lays claim to the French throne. Edward and his son, the Black Prince, win major victories at Crécy (1346) and Poitiers (1356).

1347 Calais surrenders to the English after a long siege; the town remains an English possession until 1558.

1348–50 The Black Death sweeps across Europe and kills between one-third and one-half of the French population.

1360 Under the Treaty of Bretigny, Edward III renounces his claim to the French throne in return for Aquitaine and Gascony.

1363 Duchy of Burgundy is created out of royal lands, and extends its power by gaining lands in the Rhine valley and Flanders. The dukes often ally with the English against the French kings.

1369 The French renew war and drive the English out of most of their positions by 1374.

1415 Henry V of England revives the Hundred Years War and wins a major victory at Agincourt. Under the 1420 Treaty of Troyes, he becomes regent of